

The Body Across a Lifetime

Pregnancy, postpartum, ageing, and adolescence — and the positioning that changes with every one

Learning Objectives

- Position and adapt a massage safely across pregnancy trimesters
- Adapt technique appropriately for postpartum and elderly clients
- Explain why supine positioning becomes unsafe later in pregnancy
- Apply extra consent and boundary care for adolescent clients

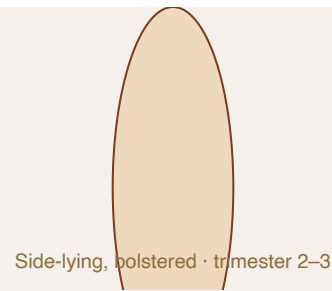
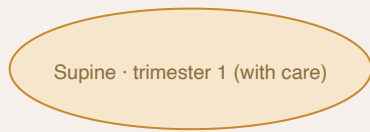
The same techniques, adjusted for the body's real season

Bodywork that is entirely appropriate for one life stage can be genuinely unsafe for another.

This module holds the same core techniques from this course and asks you to adapt them deliberately across pregnancy, postpartum recovery, older age, and adolescence.

Pregnancy: positioning changes by trimester

In the first trimester, many practitioners avoid deep abdominal work and certain pressure points traditionally cautioned against with respect to early pregnancy, while general relaxation massage is typically considered safe with medical clearance. By the second and especially third trimester, extended supine positioning (lying flat on the back) can compress the vena cava — the large vein returning blood to the heart — reducing blood flow and potentially causing dizziness or reduced circulation to the baby. Side-lying positioning, well-supported with pregnancy bolsters, becomes the standard safe position from the second trimester onward, and always proceed only with a client's confirmation that her doctor has cleared massage during her specific pregnancy.



Side-lying positioning becomes the standard from the second trimester onward to avoid vena cava compression.

Postpartum

Once medically cleared, gentle massage can support postpartum recovery, though abdominal work should remain conservative while the body recovers from delivery, and positioning should accommodate any tenderness from delivery itself, whether vaginal or caesarean.

Elderly clients

Ageing skin is frequently thinner and more fragile, per the ageing principles taught across this Atelier, and older clients are considerably more likely to be on blood-thinning medication, both factors requiring meaningfully reduced pressure and gentler handling than a standard adult protocol. Joint limitations may also require modified positioning — always ask about comfort in any position before assuming a standard table setup will work.

Adolescent clients: extra care around consent and boundaries

Any adolescent client requires heightened attention to draping, clearly explained consent at every step, and, depending on local guidance and family preference, a parent or guardian present or immediately available throughout the service. Explain each step verbally before performing it, more thoroughly than you might with an adult client, and never treat a teenager's quiet compliance as equivalent to enthusiastic, informed consent.

Key Terms

0

[object Object]

1

[object Object]

Practical Activity · The Adaptation Plan

Write a positioning and technique plan for a client in her third trimester of pregnancy, and a separate plan for an elderly client on blood-thinning medication. Be specific about positioning, bolster use, and pressure adjustments for each.